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Top 5 Policy Misconfigurations

Infra, Networking & M365

M365 policies seem easy to configure. What is often

misconfigured, and what should we look for?

Nathan Atkins / Head of Cloud Enablement - ANZ

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About Nathan Atkins



Bio

Head of Cloud Enablement - ANZ

I help MSPs and SMBs simplify Microsoft 365 management while improving security and operational maturity.

As a Microsoft Certified Trainer and security enthusiast, I specialise in Intune, Entra ID, Defender and cloud automation. I share practical lessons from the field and help organisations adopt effective, scalable and achievable security practices.

MCT / Azure Solutions Architect / M365 Admin Expert

17 years of experience / Microsoft Mentoring

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Why is policy configuration so difficult?

Microsoft 365

Why M365 policy configuration is difficult

01 Scattered across portals. Entra, Intune, Defender, Exchange and Purview each own a piece, there is no single pane of glass.

02 Policies collide. Many policies target the same setting, and each product resolves conflicts differently.

03 Defaults aren't secure. Built-in and preset policies are only a baseline, not a finished configuration.

04 Constant change. Names, defaults and features shift on cloud cadence, so guidance quietly goes stale.

05 Licensing gates it. Controls silently depend on the right SKU. No licence, no protection.

What are the top 5 policy misconfigurations?

Chances are it’s not what you think…

MISCONFIGURATION 01

Geo-blocking

Conditional Access named locations

WHY IT'S HARD TO CONFIGURE

Named-location blocks live in Conditional Access and overlap with your other CA rules, an over-broad block locks out travelling staff, roaming users and VPN egress IPs.

Geo and IP data is not based on immutable info and trivially bypassed with a VPN, so a block can give false confidence while the real gap stays open.

MISCONFIGURATION 02

Macro blocking in Intune

Attack Surface Reduction & Office macro controls

WHY IT'S HARD TO CONFIGURE

Microsoft make it hard to achieve using intune and licensing matters hugely

MISCONFIGURATION 03

Default policies & Defender for Office

Preset vs custom security policies

WHY IT'S HARD TO CONFIGURE

Default and preset security policies are only a baseline, and any custom policies layer on top with their own priority order the effective policy is hard to read.

Presets auto-update as Microsoft retunes them, so protection can shift under you and drift from what your documented rules imply.

MISCONFIGURATION 04

Compliance policies

Intune device compliance

WHY IT'S HARD TO CONFIGURE

Grace periods and the ‘mark devices with no policy as compliant’ default mean a device can look compliant before the rules actually bite.

Compliance only enforces anything when it is tied to Conditional Access — on its own it reports status but blocks nothing.

MISCONFIGURATION 05

External sharing in SharePoint & OneDrive

Tenant vs site-level sharing controls

WHY IT'S HARD TO CONFIGURE

Sharing is set at both tenant and per-site level and the tenant cap overrides the site the two must line up or sharing silently fails or over-permits.

‘Anyone’ links, guest access and unmanaged-device rules span Entra and SharePoint, making real external exposure hard to see.

Q&A

Thank You!

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